

Should We Put Up a Paywall?

A traffic-and-loyalty reality check before we tax our readers.
What it takes for a paywall to pay — and how
NotRealArt.com actually compares.

NotRealArt.com

[For discussion with Scott](#)

[June 2026](#)

THE QUESTION ON THE TABLE

The Proposal

WHAT'S BEING CONSIDERED

Install a **metered subscription paywall** on NotRealArt.com — let visitors read four or five articles free, then require a paid sign-up to read more. The goal: turn our audience into recurring subscription revenue.

THE HONEST TEST

A paywall is the right tool for some publishers. The question isn't whether paywalls *work* — it's whether **our traffic and our reader loyalty** are anywhere near the level a paywall needs to earn more than it costs.

This deck answers that test with industry benchmarks and our own UserMaven and GA4 data — before we commit engineering time and risk the reader relationship.

BEFORE WE BUILD IT — FOUR WORRIES

What A Paywall Could Cost Us

Alienate the audience

An art-lover community arrives to be inspired, not gated. A wall says "pay to look" — the opposite of the welcome we want.

No meaningful revenue

At our volume and repeat rate, the math (slides ahead) lands at roughly zero dollars — after fees and platform costs, likely negative.

Complicate the infrastructure

Accounts, billing, metering logic, churn handling, support — a whole subscription stack to maintain for a handful of dollars.

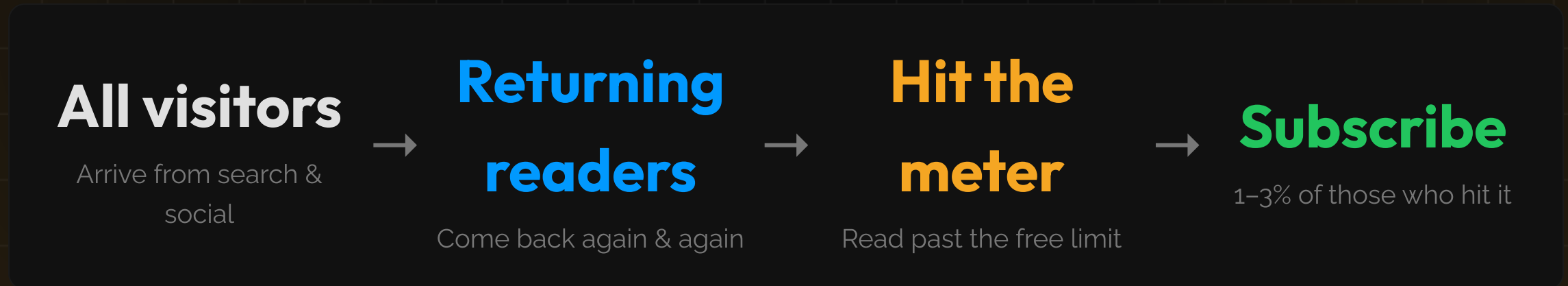
Slow the experience & dim the brand

Meter scripts and login walls add friction and load time — and signal to artists and art lovers that we monetize attention over community.

HOW THE MODEL ACTUALLY WORKS

A Metered Paywall Taxes Loyalty, Not Traffic

Revenue from a meter doesn't come from how many people visit. It comes from the small core who come back **often enough to hit the limit** — and a fraction of those who then pay. Casual one-time visitors never see the wall.



The entire engine runs on the second box — **returning readers**. If almost nobody comes back, the funnel is empty before it starts.

WHAT IT TAKES — TWO PREREQUISITES

Paywalls Need Volume AND Loyalty

PREREQUISITE 1 — VOLUME

Hundreds of thousands of pageviews a month

Only ~0.5% of monthly unique visitors ever pay. A top performer converts ~1,000 subscribers per **1,000,000** monthly pageviews; the average is ~250. The funnel only produces real money at scale.

PREREQUISITE 2 — LOYALTY

A large base of habitual return readers

Healthy news sites see **30-40%+** of traffic returning, and ~10% of readers drive 74% of revenue. The meter only earns from people loyal enough to come back and read past the limit.

Both are required. High volume with no loyalty, or high loyalty at tiny volume, still fails the math.

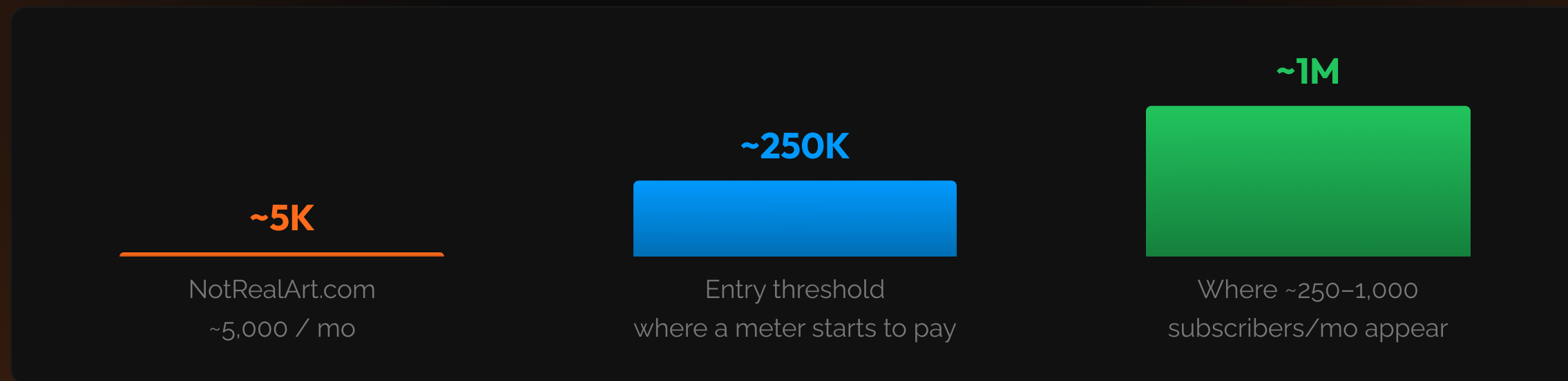
What The Benchmarks Say A Paywall Returns

Across 85+ digital publishers, the metered funnel is brutally thin at every step. These are the numbers a healthy, loyal, high-traffic publisher hits.

Monthly unique visitors who hit the paywall	3–4%
"Hit rate" — high performers vs. struggling publishers	>6% vs 1.8%
Anonymous visitor → paid subscriber (top performers)	~2.2%
Monthly unique visitors who actually pay	~0.5%
Of the <i>most engaged</i> visitors, share willing to subscribe	5–10%

Volume: We're Two Orders Of Magnitude Short

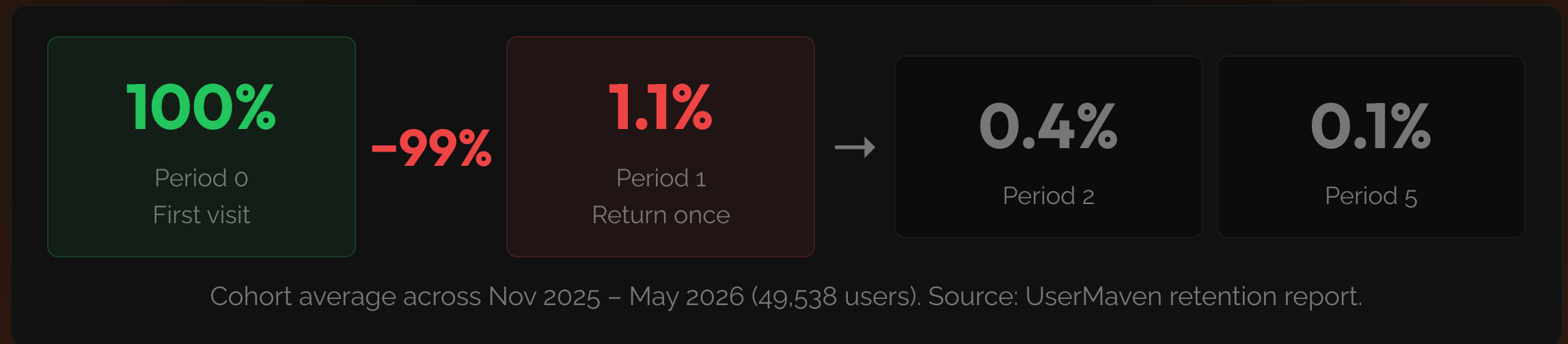
A metered paywall starts producing meaningful revenue in the **hundreds of thousands to millions** of monthly pageviews. We're at roughly **5,000 visits a month**.



At ~5,000 visits, our bar is barely a sliver. Even the *entry* threshold is ~50× our current traffic.

Loyalty: Almost No One Comes Back

Our UserMaven cohort retention. A meter earns only from **Period 1+** — the readers who return. Period 1 retention averages **1.1%**. Roughly **1 in 90 visitors ever comes back at all** — let alone often enough to read past a 5-article limit.



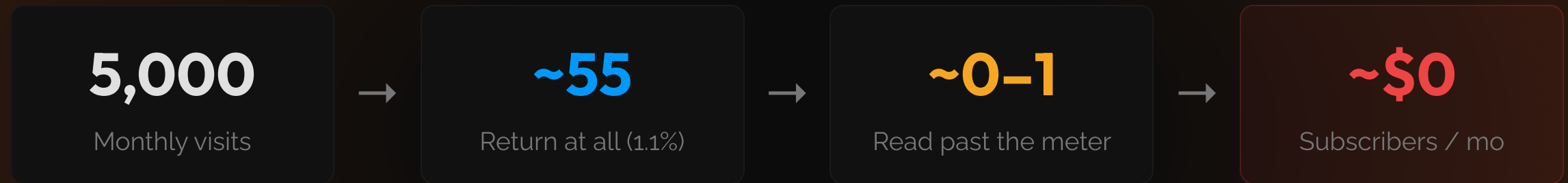
Benchmark loyalty is 30–40% returning. Ours is ~1%. The audience a paywall taxes effectively does not exist here.

GA4 independently confirms it (May 2026): new-visitor retention is just **0.9%** at day 1, 0.2% at day 7, **0.1%** by day 30 — and returning visitors are only **8.7%** of all activity, against the 30–40% a paywall needs. Two independent analytics systems, same verdict.

DO THE MATH — GENEROUS ASSUMPTIONS

Best Case, The Meter Earns ~\$0

Applying the funnel to our numbers — and being generous at every step.



EVEN WILDLY GENEROUS

Apply the benchmark 0.5%-of-uniques-pay (which assumes loyalty we don't have): $\sim 25 \text{ subs/mo} \times \$6 = \sim \$150/\text{mo}$ ceiling. Reality, given $\sim 1\%$ loyalty: closer to $\$0 - \$10/\text{mo}$.

MINUS THE COSTS

Stripe fees, a paywall platform, and ongoing dev/support time turn that ceiling **net negative**. We'd pay to run it.

WHO PAYWALLS ACTUALLY WORK FOR

We're Not That Kind Of Site

PUBLISHER	MONTHLY VOLUME	RETURN LOYALTY	WHY THE METER WORKS
The New York Times	50–100M+ visits	Daily habit	National news people check every day; 11M+ subscribers.
The Atlantic	Tens of M visits	High, repeat	Deep longform readers return for must-read essays.
Regional daily (archetype)	0.5–2M views	Local daily	Local news you can't get elsewhere — obituaries, schools, sports.
Niche trade pub (archetype)	Smaller	Must-read	Professionals expense it; the content is job-critical.
NotRealArt.com	~5K visits	~1.1% return	Episodic arts discovery — people arrive inspired, then move on.

THE REAL DIFFERENTIATOR

It's Not Size — It's Habit

WHERE METERS WIN

Recurring need

Content people **need on a schedule** — daily news, job-critical trade info. The habit creates the return visits the meter feeds on. Missing an issue has a cost.

WHERE WE LIVE

Serendipitous discovery

Art lovers find us through search and social, enjoy a piece, and **leave inspired**. That's a healthy outcome for an arts community — but it's structurally incompatible with a meter.

You can't fix a habit problem with more traffic. Even 10× the visitors, at 1% loyalty, still leaves the meter empty.

IF THE GOAL IS REVENUE — BETTER FITS

Monetize Goodwill, Not The Fifth Click

For a low-volume, high-affinity arts community, these earn without walling readers out — and several monetize the **artist side**, where the willingness to pay actually lives.

Membership / patronage

"Support us" — public-radio model. Optional, no wall, perks not gates.

Donations / pay-what-you-want

Lower friction than subscriptions; builds trust instead of spending it.

Sponsorship & partnerships

Galleries, art brands, supply companies reach our exact audience.

Paid artist spotlights

Artists pay for promotion — aligned incentives, readers stay free.

Affiliate & marketplace

Prints, books, supplies — revenue from what readers already want.

Events & workshops

Paid community, classes, ticketed gatherings — depth over toll-gates.

The Recommendation

Don't build a paywall now. At ~5,000 visits and ~1% return loyalty, a meter earns ~\$0 while adding cost, friction, and a "pay to look" signal to a community that comes to be inspired.

NOW

Pursue no-wall revenue: membership, sponsorship, and paid artist spotlights. Keep the reading experience open and fast.

REVISIT ONLY WHEN

Traffic clears ~100K/mo AND returning-visitor share clears ~20-30% with a measurable super-user core.

Sources & References

Evidence behind the claims in this deck

~0.5% of monthly uniques pay; ~3–4% hit the wall; ~250–1,000 subs per 1M pageviews — Nieman Lab metered-paywall data (2014), via WebPublisherPro.

Anon→subscriber ~2.2% (top); 1–3% typical; registered→sub ~19% — Piano / Audiencers Subscription & Conversion Funnel Benchmarks.

Meter-stop-rate target 5–7%; hit rate >6% vs 1.8% struggling — Pool / The Audiencers.

5–10% of most-engaged willing to subscribe — Admiral; Quintype.

~10% of readers drive ~74% of revenue (super-users) — Bounteous, 2019.

Pure metering fell 35% (2017) → 9% (2023) of publishers — WAN-IFRA / Pool.

Only 20% of Americans pay for any online news; growth plateaued — Reuters Institute Digital News Report 2025.

Donation/membership fits small niche audiences better than a wall — Elegant Themes; Donorbox.

NotRealArt.com: ~5,000 visits/mo; Period-1 retention ~1.1% (49,538 users, Nov 2025–May 2026) — UserMaven retention report, retrieved 2026-06-01.

NotRealArt.com (GA4): returning visitors 8.7% of activity; new-visitor retention 0.9% (day 1), 0.1% (day 30) — Google Analytics 4 Retention report, May 5–Jun 1 2026, retrieved 2026-06-02.